SPEED UP ANY OLD COMPUTER

Make It Feel Brand New — No Tech Skills Needed

Faster Boot	Better Browsing	Storage Fixes	Free Upgrades

WHAT'S INSIDE:

Startup Fixes • Windows Tune-Ups • Browser Speed • Storage Cleanup • RAM & SSD Upgrades

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Introduction

Why Your Computer Slows Down — And What You Can Do About It

You remember the day you got it. Everything was instant. Programs opened in a blink, websites loaded straight away, and the whole thing felt *fast*. Now, a few years later, it groans to life in the morning, freezes when you open a browser, and takes so long to do anything that you've started wondering whether you need a new one.

Here's what nobody tells you: in most cases, the hardware is fine. The same processor that was fast three years ago is still the same processor today. What's changed is everything piled on top of it — software updates, apps that sneak into your startup, a hard drive filling up, and a dozen programs all trying to run at once in the background. That's the real culprit.

This guide fixes all of that. We'll start with things you can do in the next five minutes that will make a noticeable difference today. Then we'll go deeper — cleaning up what's running, adjusting how Windows behaves, and dealing with browsers that have quietly become performance hogs. If software isn't enough, we'll look at two hardware upgrades that have transformed more slow computers than anything else: adding RAM and switching to an SSD. Neither of these requires any technical background.

■ **GOOD TO KNOW**

This guide is written for Windows 10 and Windows 11. Most steps are identical across both. Where they differ, both versions are shown. Mac users: a number of sections — especially browser, storage, and hardware — apply to you too.

You don't need to do everything in this guide. Even working through the first two sections will make a real difference. Think of the rest as a toolkit — dip into whatever applies to your situation.

One rule before we start: don't delete anything you're not sure about, and don't change settings you don't recognise. Every step in this guide tells you exactly what to do and why. If something isn't clear, skip it — there are plenty of other improvements that are completely safe for anyone.

1 Quick Wins — Speed Boosts in Under 5 Minutes

■ TIME	**5–15 minutes**
■ EFFORT	**Very Easy**
■ SAVINGS	**Potentially big**

Before we dig into anything complicated, let's do a few things that take almost no time and can make an immediate difference. Many people find these steps alone are enough to feel a significant improvement.

1.1 — Restart Your Computer (Properly)

If you typically close the lid or hit the power button, you may not be restarting — you're just suspending. Windows has a "Fast Startup" feature that isn't truly a full restart. Over days and weeks, memory fills up, temporary files build, and programs accumulate in the background. A proper restart clears all of that.

How to do a proper restart:

- Click the Start menu (bottom left Windows icon)
- Click the Power button icon
- Choose **Restart** — NOT Shut down (shut down with Fast Startup enabled doesn't fully clear RAM)
- Wait for it to fully boot back up before judging the speed

■ **TIP**

Make restarting a habit. Once a week is enough for most people. If your computer stays on 24/7, restarting regularly is one of the simplest free improvements you can make.

1.2 — Check What's Eating Your Resources Right Now

Task Manager shows you in real time exactly what's using your CPU, RAM, and disk. You might discover one program is quietly hogging everything — and simply closing it gives you your computer back.

How to open Task Manager:

- Press **Ctrl + Shift + Esc** on your keyboard
- Click the **Processes** tab at the top
- Click the **CPU** column header to sort by highest usage
- Look for anything using 30% or more that you don't recognise
- Right-click it and choose **End Task** if it's something you can safely close

■■ **WATCH OUT**

Don't end tasks for anything labelled System, Windows, or antivirus. Ending the wrong process can cause Windows to crash. If you're not sure what something is, Google the name before closing it.

1.3 — Plug In Your Laptop

If you use a laptop on battery, Windows automatically reduces performance to save power. Your CPU runs slower, background processes are throttled, and the whole machine holds back. Plugging in switches to a higher performance mode instantly.

You can also change your Power Plan manually: go to **Control Panel** → **Power Options** and select **Balanced** or **High Performance**. Avoid "Power Saver" mode unless you genuinely need maximum battery life.

■ **GOOD TO KNOW**

Windows 11 users: go to **Settings** → **System** → **Power & Sleep** → **Power mode** and set it to **Best performance** when plugged in.

2 Startup Fixes — Stop Programs Slowing Your Boot

■ TIME	10–20 minutes
■ EFFORT	Easy
■ SAVINGS	Often dramatic

Every time you install a program, it often adds itself to your startup list — meaning it launches automatically when you turn on your computer, whether you want it to or not. After a few years, dozens of programs can be fighting to start at once, turning a 30-second boot into a 3-minute wait. This section fixes that.

2.1 — Disable Startup Programs

This is one of the highest-impact things you can do. Every program you disable from startup means one fewer thing your computer has to load before you can use it.

Step-by-step:

- Press **Ctrl + Shift + Esc** to open Task Manager
- Click the **Startup** tab at the top
- You'll see a list of programs with a "Startup impact" column (Low, Medium, High)
- Right-click any program with **High** or **Medium** impact that you don't need at startup
- Choose **Disable**
- Restart your computer and notice the difference

What's Safe to Disable vs What to Keep

■ Usually Safe to Disable	■ Keep These Enabled
Spotify, Steam, Discord	Your antivirus / security software
OneDrive (if you don't use it)	Windows Defender / Security
Skype, Teams (start it yourself when needed)	Realtek audio software (affects sound)
Adobe Creative Cloud launcher	Touchpad drivers (laptops)
iTunes / Apple software updater	Any software your workplace requires
Zoom, Slack (launch when you need them)	
Any game launchers (Epic, GOG, etc.)	

■ **TIP**

Don't know what a startup program does? Right-click it in Task Manager and choose "Search online" — Windows will search for it automatically. Or just Google the program name. If you can't find anything useful, it's probably safe to disable. You can always re-enable it if something stops working.

2.2 — Check Boot Times with Reliability Monitor

Windows keeps a hidden log of how your computer is performing, including how long boots take and any errors. You can use this to see whether your changes are making a difference.

How to open it:

- Press the **Windows key**, type **"Reliability Monitor"**, and press Enter
- You'll see a graph of your computer's recent stability and performance
- Look at the dates — any crashes, errors, or unusual events are shown here
- After you make changes, check back a few days later to see improvements

3 Windows Performance Tweaks

■ TIME	20–30 minutes
■ EFFORT	Easy–Moderate
■ SAVINGS	Medium–Large

Windows comes with a lot of visual effects and features that look nice but use up processing power and memory. On a new, high-powered computer they don't matter much. On an older or slower machine, turning them off can make things noticeably snappier.

3.1 — Turn Off Visual Effects

Windows adds animations, shadows, and fades to make things look polished. On slower computers, these make the whole interface feel sluggish. Turning them off makes windows open and close instantly.

- Press the **Windows key**, type **"Adjust the appearance and performance of Windows"**
- Click the result to open Performance Options
- Select **"Adjust for best performance"** — this turns everything off at once
- Or choose **"Custom"** and keep just the ones you like
- Click **Apply** then **OK**

■ TIP

If turning off all effects makes things look too plain, try enabling just "Show thumbnails instead of icons" and "Smooth edges of screen fonts" — these have almost no performance cost but keep things readable.

3.2 — Adjust Virtual Memory (Page File)

When your computer runs out of real RAM, it uses part of your hard drive as "virtual memory" — a slower substitute. By default, Windows manages this automatically, but you can sometimes improve performance by setting it manually.

■ GOOD TO KNOW

Only do this if you have less than 8GB of RAM and regularly see your computer slow to a crawl when many programs are open. If you have 16GB or more, skip this section.

- Press **Windows key + Pause/Break** to open System Properties, or search "View advanced system settings"
- Click **Advanced** tab → under Performance click **Settings**

- Click **Advanced** tab → under Virtual Memory click **Change**
- Uncheck "Automatically manage paging file size"
- Select your C: drive, choose "Custom size"
- Set Initial size to 1.5× your RAM in MB (e.g. 4GB RAM = 6144 MB)
- Set Maximum size to 3× your RAM in MB (e.g. 4GB RAM = 12288 MB)
- Click **Set** → **OK** → restart

3.3 — Disable Search Indexing (If You Rarely Use Search)

Windows constantly indexes your files in the background so searches are faster. On an older hard drive, this indexing can noticeably slow things down. If you rarely use Windows Search to find files, you can turn it off.

- Press **Windows key + R**, type **services.msc**, press Enter
- Scroll down to find **Windows Search**
- Right-click it and choose **Properties**
- Change "Startup type" to **Disabled**
- Click **Stop**, then **OK**

> **■■ WATCH OUT**
> If you regularly use the Start menu search bar to find files, programs, or settings, leave Windows Search enabled. Disabling it will make Start menu searches much slower or completely non-functional.

3.4 — Run Disk Cleanup

Windows accumulates temporary files, old update files, and cached data over time. Disk Cleanup removes these safely. On an older machine you might recover gigabytes of space — and a fuller drive runs slower.

- Press **Windows key**, type **"Disk Cleanup"**, press Enter
- Select your C: drive and click **OK**
- Check all the boxes (Temporary files, Recycle Bin, etc.)
- Click **"Clean up system files"** for even more — this removes old Windows update files
- Click **OK** and confirm — the cleanup runs automatically

4 Browser Speed & the Internet Slowdown

■ TIME	15 minutes
■ EFFORT	Very Easy
■ SAVINGS	Often significant

For most people, the browser is the most-used program on their computer. It's also one of the biggest memory hogs — and over time it accumulates extensions, cached data, and bad habits that make everything slower. This section deals with the browser-specific side of slowness that people often mistake for a hardware problem.

4.1 — Clear Your Browser Cache & Cookies

Your browser stores copies of websites you visit to make them load faster. Over time this cache can grow to gigabytes and actually slow things down rather than speed them up. Clearing it is safe and takes under a minute.

In Chrome:

- Press **Ctrl + Shift + Delete**
- Set time range to **"All time"**
- Check: Browsing history, Cookies, Cached images and files
- Click **Clear data**

In Firefox:

- Press **Ctrl + Shift + Delete**
- Select **"Everything"** from the time range
- Check all boxes and click **Clear Now**

In Edge:

- Press **Ctrl + Shift + Delete**
- Choose time range **"All time"**, check all boxes
- Click **Clear now**

4.2 — Audit Your Extensions

Browser extensions are one of the most overlooked causes of slow browsing. Each extension runs alongside every webpage you visit. If you have ten extensions installed and only use two of them, you're carrying dead weight on every page load.

- **Chrome:** Go to chrome://extensions in your address bar

- **Firefox:** Press **Ctrl + Shift + A**
- **Edge:** Go to edge://extensions
- Disable or remove any extension you don't actively use
- Pay special attention to VPNs, ad blockers, and coupon/shopping tools — these are heavy

> **TIP**
> A good test: disable all extensions, then visit a site that's been loading slowly. If it loads faster, re-enable extensions one by one until you find the culprit. You can disable extensions temporarily without losing their settings.

4.3 — Stop Opening Dozens of Tabs

Each open browser tab uses memory — even the ones you're not actively looking at. 30 open tabs can use as much RAM as a demanding program. If you keep tabs open because you don't want to lose them, use bookmarks or a tab-saving extension instead.

Extensions like **OneTab** (Chrome/Firefox/Edge) let you collapse all open tabs into a single list with one click, freeing all that memory instantly. You can restore individual tabs whenever you need them.

4.4 — Consider Switching Browsers

If you're using an old version of Internet Explorer or an outdated browser, that alone could explain slow web browsing. Modern sites are built for modern browsers. Switching to **Chrome**, **Firefox**, or **Edge** (all free) will make most websites load dramatically faster on the same hardware.

5 Storage Cleanup — Free Up Space & Speed

■ TIME	**20–40 minutes**
■ EFFORT	**Easy**
■ SAVINGS	**Medium — plus more free space**

A hard drive that's nearly full doesn't just mean you can't save more files — it actively slows down your computer. Windows needs free space to create temporary files, manage virtual memory, and write updates. When you're below 10–15% free space, things get noticeably sluggish. This section helps you claw that space back.

5.1 — Find What's Taking Up Space

Before deleting anything, it helps to see exactly where your storage is being used. Windows has a built-in tool for this, and there are free options that give you an even clearer picture.

Built-in Storage Sense (Windows 10/11):

- Go to **Settings** → **System** → **Storage**
- Windows shows a breakdown of what's using your drive (Apps, Temporary files, etc.)
- Click any category to see details and options to clean up
- Turn on **Storage Sense** to automatically clean up temp files on a schedule

> ■ **GOOD TO KNOW**
> For a more detailed view of every folder and file, try the free tool **WinDirStat** (search "WinDirStat" in your browser). It shows a colour-coded map of every file on your drive so you can instantly see what's taking up the most space. Especially useful for finding forgotten downloads, old backups, or rogue video files.

5.2 — Clean Out the Downloads Folder

The Downloads folder is where things go to be forgotten. Installers from years ago, PDFs you opened once, videos, zip files — most people's Downloads folder is a graveyard of things they'll never open again. Sorting it by size can be eye-opening: it's common to find several gigabytes of files you completely forgot about.

- Open **File Explorer** (the yellow folder icon on your taskbar)
- Click **Downloads** on the left sidebar
- Click the **Size** column header to sort by largest files first
- Delete anything you don't need — installers, old zip files, duplicate downloads

- Empty the Recycle Bin afterwards to actually free the space

5.3 — Move Files to an External Drive or Cloud

If you have lots of photos, videos, or documents that you don't need to access every day, moving them off your main drive is one of the best things you can do. A 1TB external hard drive costs $50–$80 and can hold years of photos and videos.

Cloud storage is another option. **Google Drive** gives you 15GB free, **OneDrive** (built into Windows) gives 5GB, and **iCloud** is available if you're in the Apple ecosystem. These won't replace a full backup but are useful for documents you want accessible anywhere.

5.4 — Uninstall Programs You Don't Use

Programs you never open still take up drive space, and some run background services that use CPU and RAM. Uninstalling them removes both the space and the background activity.

- Go to **Settings** → **Apps** → **Apps & Features**
- Sort by **Size** to see the biggest programs first
- Click any program you don't use and select **Uninstall**
- Common candidates: old games, trials you never used, manufacturer bloatware

6 Virus & Bloatware — Hidden Speed Killers

■ TIME	30–60 minutes
■ EFFORT	Easy
■ SAVINGS	Potentially huge

Malware and bloatware are two of the most common reasons computers slow to a crawl — and two of the most overlooked. Malware is obvious: it's running hidden processes, using your internet connection, and hogging resources for things you never agreed to. Bloatware is sneakier: it's all the software manufacturers bundle onto PCs that you never wanted and probably never use, but which quietly runs in the background.

6.1 — Run a Malware Scan

Windows comes with its own antivirus called **Windows Defender** (or Windows Security in Windows 11). For most people it's good enough. But it can miss some things, and running a second opinion scan is always worthwhile.

Quick scan with Windows Defender:

- Press **Windows key**, type **"Windows Security"**
- Click **Virus & threat protection**
- Click **Quick scan** — takes 5–10 minutes
- If it finds anything, follow the prompts to remove it

■ **GOOD TO KNOW**

Malwarebytes (free version) is excellent for catching things Windows Defender might miss. Download it from malwarebytes.com, run a scan, and then you can uninstall it afterwards if you prefer — you don't need to keep it installed.

6.2 — Remove Manufacturer Bloatware

If you bought a computer from HP, Dell, Lenovo, Acer, or another manufacturer, it almost certainly came loaded with extra software you didn't ask for — trial antivirus programs, games, shopping apps, and manufacturer-specific tools that often serve no real purpose. Many of these run at startup.

Go to **Settings** → **Apps** → **Apps & Features** and look for things like:

- McAfee LiveSafe / Norton trials (often aggressive — remove fully using their own uninstaller tool)
- Any "Games" or shopping apps you didn't install
- Manufacturer companion apps (HP Support Assistant, Dell SupportAssist, etc.) — safe to remove

- "Get Office" or trial software you have no intention of using
- Candy Crush, Bubble Witch, or other games bundled with Windows

■■ WATCH OUT

Be careful with antivirus trials. Simply going to Apps and uninstalling them often leaves behind traces that continue running. Use the antivirus maker's own dedicated removal tool — search "[antivirus name] removal tool" to find it. Norton, McAfee, and AVG all have free official removal tools.

7 Hardware Upgrades — When Software Isn't Enough

TIME	Varies
EFFORT	Easy–Moderate
SAVINGS	Very Large

You've restarted, cleared the startup list, cleaned up the drive, sorted the browser, and removed everything you don't need. If your computer still feels slow, the honest answer is that you've hit the limits of what software can do. At this point, two hardware upgrades are worth knowing about — and both of them are much easier and cheaper than buying a new computer.

The two upgrades that will help most people with a slow computer are:

Upgrade	What It Fixes	Typical Cost	Difficulty	Impact
More RAM	Computer freezes when multiple programs are open; everything lags when browser tabs pile up	$40–$80	Easy	High
SSD	Slow startup; programs take ages to open; saving files feels like waiting for a bus	$60–$100	Moderate	Very High

The next two sections cover each upgrade in detail — what to buy, how to check compatibility, and how to install it. If you only do one, do the SSD. It will make more difference than anything else in this guide combined.

Before You Buy Anything

The single most important step is checking whether your computer can actually be upgraded. Some laptops — particularly thin ultrabooks — have RAM soldered directly to the motherboard, meaning it can't be changed. Section 8 and 9 both start with how to check compatibility before spending a penny.

8 RAM Upgrade — The Easiest Hardware Fix

■ TIME	**30–45 minutes**
■ EFFORT	**Easy**
■ SAVINGS	**High if RAM is the bottleneck**

RAM (Random Access Memory) is your computer's short-term memory. It holds the programs and files you're currently using so your CPU can access them instantly. When you run out of RAM, your computer starts using the hard drive as a substitute — which is many times slower. This is what causes that agonising freeze when you have too many programs open at once.

8.1 — Do You Actually Need More RAM?

Adding RAM only helps if RAM is your bottleneck. Here's how to tell:

- Open Task Manager (**Ctrl + Shift + Esc**)
- Click the **Performance** tab
- Click **Memory** on the left
- Look at the **In use** vs **Available** reading
- If you're regularly using more than 80% of your RAM when doing normal tasks, more RAM will help

■ GOOD TO KNOW

How much RAM do you have? The Performance tab shows this clearly. As a rough guide: 4GB is the minimum for Windows 10/11 and will feel slow; 8GB is the comfortable minimum for everyday use; 16GB is ideal for anyone who multitasks or uses demanding programs.

8.2 — Check if Your RAM Can Be Upgraded

This step is critical. Some computers — especially slim laptops — have RAM soldered to the motherboard and cannot be upgraded. Check before buying anything.

Easiest method — Crucial System Scanner:

- Go to **crucial.com** and look for their free System Scanner tool
- Download and run it (it's safe — Crucial is one of the world's biggest memory manufacturers)
- It automatically detects your computer and tells you exactly what RAM is compatible
- It also tells you if your RAM is upgradeable at all

TIP
You can also search for your exact laptop or desktop model + "RAM upgrade" on YouTube. Someone has almost certainly done it before and filmed a step-by-step video of their exact model. This is the best way to see what you're dealing with before you open anything up.

8.3 — Installing RAM

If your computer is upgradeable and you've bought compatible RAM, the installation itself is usually simple — especially on desktop PCs. On laptops it varies by model.

Desktop RAM installation:

- Shut down completely and unplug from the wall
- Open the side panel (usually one or two screws, or a sliding latch)
- Touch a metal part of the case to discharge any static electricity
- Locate the RAM sticks — long thin boards with a gold edge, near the CPU
- Press the clips at each end to release the old RAM stick(s)
- Insert the new RAM stick(s) — line up the notch and press firmly until the clips click
- Replace the panel, plug back in, and power on
- Check Task Manager → Performance → Memory to confirm the new amount is showing

9 SSD Upgrade — The Biggest Speed Jump Possible

TIME	1–3 hours
EFFORT	Moderate
SAVINGS	Transformational

If there's one upgrade that can make an old computer feel genuinely new again, it's replacing a traditional hard drive (HDD) with a Solid State Drive (SSD). The numbers tell the story: a standard hard drive reads data at around 100–150MB per second. A basic SSD reads at 500MB per second or more. That's a 5× speed jump on every single operation your computer does — opening programs, loading Windows, saving files, everything.

Computers that take 3–4 minutes to start up can boot in 15–20 seconds after an SSD upgrade. Programs that took 30 seconds to open can open in 2–3 seconds. It genuinely feels like a new machine.

9.1 — HDD vs SSD: What's the Difference?

	Traditional HDD	SSD
Speed	100–150 MB/s	**500–7000 MB/s**
Boot time	1–4 minutes	**10–20 seconds**
Noise	Audible clicking/spinning	**Completely silent**
Fragile?	Yes — moving parts	**No — no moving parts**
Price (1TB)	$40–$60	**$60–$100**
Lifespan	3–5 years average	**5–10 years average**

9.2 — What Type of SSD Do You Need?

SSDs come in different physical sizes and connection types. The right one depends on your computer. The two most common are:

- **2.5-inch SATA SSD** — Same size as a laptop hard drive, connects the same way. Works in most laptops and desktops that currently have a hard drive. This is the easiest swap.
- **M.2 NVMe SSD** — A small stick that plugs directly into the motherboard. Much faster than SATA, but only works if your computer has an M.2 slot. Most computers from 2016 onwards have one.

■ **TIP**

Not sure which type your computer has? The Crucial System Scanner (from Section 8) will tell you. Or search your exact laptop/desktop model + "SSD upgrade" — you'll quickly find which type other people have used successfully in the same model.

9.3 — Cloning Your Drive (Copying Everything Across)

You don't have to reinstall Windows from scratch. You can use free software to copy your entire existing drive — Windows, programs, files, settings, everything — onto the new SSD. This is called cloning and it means you switch to the new drive without losing anything.

What you need:

- Your new SSD
- A USB-to-SATA adapter cable ($10–$20) — this lets you connect the new SSD via USB while cloning
- **Macrium Reflect Free** — the best free cloning software (search: macrium reflect free download)

The cloning process:

- Connect new SSD via USB adapter
- Download and install Macrium Reflect Free
- Open it and click **"Clone this disk"**
- Select your C: drive as the source
- Select your new SSD as the destination
- Click Clone and wait — typically 30–90 minutes depending on how much data you have
- When done, shut down, swap the drives physically, boot from the new SSD
- Your computer should boot to your normal Windows desktop — nothing lost

■■ **WATCH OUT**

Before cloning, check that the new SSD has enough capacity to hold everything on your current drive. If your current drive is 500GB and is 80% full, a 500GB SSD will work. A 250GB SSD would not have enough space for the clone.

10 Keeping It Fast — Your Monthly Maintenance Plan

■ TIME	5–15 min/month
■ EFFORT	Very Easy
■ SAVINGS	Prevents slowdown returning

The sad truth about computer maintenance is that it's not a one-time fix. Temporary files build back up. New programs add themselves to startup. Browsers fill up their caches again. The good news is that a simple monthly routine — 15 minutes, no real technical knowledge required — can keep everything running smoothly indefinitely.

Monthly Checklist

- ✓ **Restart your computer**
  If you don't do this regularly already — do it now
- ✓ **Run Disk Cleanup**
  Delete temp files, empty Recycle Bin, clear old update files
- ✓ **Check startup programs**
  Have any new programs sneaked onto the startup list?
- ✓ **Clear browser cache**
  Ctrl + Shift + Delete in Chrome, Firefox, or Edge
- ✓ **Check drive free space**
  Should stay above 15% — if below, do a storage cleanup
- ✓ **Run a quick security scan**
  Windows Security → Quick Scan

Annual Tasks

- **Check for Windows Updates** — let them install fully (don't skip them)
- **Review installed programs** — uninstall anything you haven't opened in a year
- **Back up your files** — external drive or cloud. Do this before making any changes
- **Check drive health** — use CrystalDiskInfo (free) to check for early warning signs of drive failure
- **Clean the dust** — if you're comfortable opening your computer, dust buildup on fans causes overheating and slowdowns

■ TIP

Set a calendar reminder on your phone for the 1st of each month: '15-minute PC cleanup'. The whole routine — restart, disk cleanup, cache clear, quick scan — takes less time than making a cup of tea. Do it consistently and your computer will stay fast.

★ Bonus: When to Repair vs Replace — Honest Advice

This guide has given you a lot of tools to speed up your current computer. But there comes a point where no amount of software tweaking or affordable hardware upgrades will fix the underlying problem — the machine is simply too old and underpowered for what modern software demands.

Here's an honest framework for making that decision:

Signs You Should Repair / Speed Up (Worth It)

✓ Computer is less than 8 years old

✓ Has a traditional HDD (SSD upgrade will transform it)

✓ Has 4GB RAM (upgrading to 8GB will make a real difference)

✓ Runs slow mainly on startup or when opening programs

✓ Hardware is physically fine — no overheating, no drive errors

✓ Replacing it would cost $500+ and the upgrade costs $60–$120

Signs You Should Replace It

■ More than 10 years old and struggling with basic tasks

■ RAM is soldered and can't be upgraded, and it has less than 4GB

■ SSD already installed and it's still very slow (processor is the bottleneck)

■ Hard drive showing errors in CrystalDiskInfo — imminent failure risk

■ Can't install Windows 11 due to hardware requirements (TPM, CPU)

■ Repair costs would exceed 50% of a replacement's value

■ The Rule of Thumb

If a $60–$100 SSD upgrade would give you another 3–4 years of usable life, that's $20 per year — one of the best value tech decisions you can make. But if the machine is fundamentally too slow, too old, or failing, chasing improvements becomes throwing money at a problem. Be honest about which situation you're in.

What You've Learned in This Guide

✓ Restart regularly and check Task Manager for rogue processes

✓ Disable startup programs you don't need

✓ Turn off Windows visual effects on older machines

✓ Clean browser cache and remove unused extensions

✓ Keep at least 15% of your drive free at all times

✓ Run a malware scan and remove bloatware

✓ Add RAM if you regularly max it out

✓ Switch to an SSD — the single biggest speed improvement possible

✓ Maintain monthly to prevent slowdown creeping back